HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Introduction to HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Given Monday 9 February 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Series Overview

New Monday night series — follows three completed sefarim over ~6–7 years:

1. **Derech Hashem** (Ramchal)
2. **Da'at Tevunot** (Ramchal)
3. **Emunot VeDe'ot** (Rav Sa'adia Gaon) — the first systematic theology of Torah; studied by the Rambam who elaborated on many of Sa'adia's ideas

Parallel learning: Tuesday nights approaching the end of Rambam's Hakdama to Perek Chelek, after which the shiur will begin **Moreh Nevuchim** — so both sefarim will run in parallel.

Background: The Rambam

- **Born:** Nissan, 1135 (main view) or 1138, in Cordoba
- **Died:** Tevet, December 1204, in Fustat (Old Cairo)
- Lived approximately **69 years**
- To the best of our knowledge, his **only child** was Rabbi Avraham (born when Rambam was ~51 years old)

Why the Name "Avraham"?

From a letter Rambam wrote to **Rabbi Yosef ben Yehuda** (the dedicatee of the Moreh Nevuchim):

"My son Avraham — Hashem gave him grace and blessing from the blessing of the one he is called after" — i.e., **Avraham Avinu**.

Rambam describes his son as:

- Extremely humble (ענו ושפל שבאנשים)
- Of great character and traits (טוב מידותיו)
- Possessing a fine intellect and good nature (בעל שכל דק וטבע נאה)
- Destined for fame: "יהיה לו בעזרת השם שם בגדולים בלא ספק"

Dating the letter: Likely written in **1201** (Rabbi Avraham aged ~15), a few years before Rambam's death in 1204.

The Pattern of Names Across Three Generations

Generation	Father	Son Named	Reason
Rabbi Maimon	—	**Moshe**	Great reverence for Moshe Rabbeinu; Maimon added Tehillim 90 (תפילה למשה) daily before Baruch She'amar
Rambam (Moshe)	—	**Avraham**	After Moshe, Avraham Avinu was Rambam's most revered figure; couldn't name him Moshe (his own name)
Rabbi Avraham	—	**David** & **Ovadya**	David — after Rambam's brother who drowned at sea; Ovadya (עבד ה׳) — reflecting the theme of his book HaMaspik Le'Ovdei Hashem

Rabbi Avraham himself writes (in his commentary on Bereishit, on ותמות דבורה מינקת רבקה) that naming someone after an important person gives them some positive change to their character and identity.

Biography of Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam

Key Dates

- **Born:** Sivan (June) 1186, Fustat, Egypt
- **Died:** 1237, aged **51**
- Father died when he was only **18–19 years old**

Torah Learning

- Learned most of his Torah — both **halacha** and **machshava** — directly from his father
- There were things Rambam told him **privately** that he would not record in writing
- Example: On the pasuk "עין תחת עין" — Rabbi Avraham says he received something from his father but cannot disclose it
- Rambam himself in Moreh Nevuchim III:41 writes: "I have my opinion about this law which I'll only express verbally" (עם זאת יש לי דעה גם לגבי הלכה זו שתשמע על פה)

Public Life & Communal Role

- Became **Nagid** (head of the Jewish community / representative to the government) at age **19**
- The position of Nagid continued in his family for ~150 years through to his great-great-grandson Rabbi Avraham Maimoni
- **Doctor** like his father; **manager of a hospital** in Cairo
- Traveled regularly between Fustat (Old Cairo) and New Cairo for hospital duties
- Invoked Shir HaShirim: "כרמי שלי לא נטרתי" — lamenting he couldn't attend to his own development due to communal responsibilities

Fame & Recognition

- At age **25** (1211), a group of **Baalei Tosafot** from France on their way to Eretz Yisrael stopped in Fustat specifically to meet him
- **Titles given to him:**

- "Young in years but great in wisdom" — Rabbi Yehuda Al-Harizi

Maharam Alshakar (15th century Egypt) — חסיד

"The Prince of God is in our midst" — נשיא אלוקים בתוכנו

"The Shechina dwells among us through him" — שכינה שרויה בנינו

"Head of all the pious" — ראש כל החסידים

Rabbi Avraham's Works

Book	Subject
HaMaspik Le'Ovdei Hashem	Comprehensive guide to serving Hashem (the sefer we are studying)
Commentary on Bereishit & Shemot	Torah commentary (unclear if he completed beyond these)
Maaseh Nissim	Refutation of Daniel HaBavli's 47 challenges to the Mishneh Torah
Birkat Avraham	Refutation of Daniel HaBavli's 13 challenges to the Moreh Nevuchim
Milchamot Hashem	Defence of the Rambam against the broader controversies (especially after the burning of the Moreh in Montpellier)
Teshuvot / Responsa	Various halachic responses
Commentary on Rambam's Pirush HaMishnayot	Written at a young age

Note on Daniel HaBavli: Despite being urged to place him in cherem, Rabbi Avraham refused, saying it would appear to be a conflict of interest.

Rabbi Avraham's Unique Approach

Personal & Experiential vs. Intellectual

- **Rambam** emphasised the **intellectual** understanding of Hashem
- **Rabbi Avraham** emphasised a **personal, experiential** encounter with Hashem
- These complement each other — as Rambam himself writes (Moreh III:51): after intellectual understanding of God, the goal is constant focus and standing before Hashem — "וזהו עבודת השם המיוחדת"

The Question of Abstinence (Perishut)

Rabbi Avraham adopted practices of **chasidut/perishut** including:

- Waking at night for prayer/meditation
- Extensive bowing and prostration during prayer
- Wearing uncomfortable clothing (e.g., coarse wool)
- Various forms of self-denial

The apparent contradiction with Rambam: In Shemoneh Perakim (Ch. 4), Rambam explicitly criticises such practices:

> "כסילים חסידים עשו אלה הפעולות... יענו את גופותם בכל מיני ענוי" — Foolish pious people afflict their bodies... these are bad things.

Resolution: Rambam himself acknowledges (in the same chapter) that certain Chassidim did these things as a form of **healing** — temporary measures to correct imbalance, like bitter medicine for illness. Rabbi Avraham may have seen his generation as needing this corrective.

Relationship with Sufism

- Rabbi Avraham openly acknowledged learning from **Sufi** practices of abstinence and purity
- **His principle:** He only adopted practices for which he could find evidence that the **Nevi'im** or **Chassidim HaRishonim** had engaged in them
- This was not "influence" but **reawakening** lost Jewish practices that Muslims had originally received from us
- **What he rejected:** e.g., the Sufi practice of repeating God's name many times — he found no Jewish source for this
- He received criticism for some of these innovations (e.g., additional bowings in prayer)

His Father-in-Law's Influence

- Married the daughter of **Rabbi Chananel ben Shmuel HaDayan**, himself a Dayan in Fustat and known as a **Chassid** — possibly where Rabbi Avraham developed his orientation toward chasidut

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The Book: HaMaspik Le'Ovdei Hashem

Title

- **Arabic:** כפאיה אלעאבדין — Kifayat Al-Abidin
- **Hebrew (by Rabbi Avraham himself):** אומספיק לעובדי השם — with the "ו" prefix suggesting **"a sufficient guide"** rather than "the definitive guide"
- **Feldheim English title:** "The Guide to Serving God" — but this loses the word "maspik" (sufficient/enough)
- **Better translation:** "A Sufficient Guide to Serving God"

Concept: Just as Rambam wrote the Mishneh Torah as the sufficient guide for **halacha**, Rabbi Avraham wrote this as the sufficient guide for **avodat Hashem** in practice.

Structure of the Complete Work

The full HaMaspik consisted of **4 parts with 10 sections total:**

Part	Content	Status
Part 1	Torah study, Shabbat, Festivals	Mostly lost
Part 2	Incorporeality of God, Prayer, Bowing, Tefillin, Mezuzah, Vows, Speech	Mostly lost
Part 3	Interpersonal relationships, Financial law, Marriage, Charity	Mostly lost
Part 4	**Derech HaChasidut** — The Way of the Pious	**What we have and will be studying**

The first three parts were **practical halacha** interweaved with musar — a very practical guide (like modern "practical laws of Shabbat" etc.), in contrast to his father's Mishneh Torah which codified the entire Torah including non-applicable laws.

Completion & Spread

- **Completed:** 1230 (a few years before his death in 1237)
- Spread to: Egypt, Syria, Lebanon, Safed, Algeria, and even **France** (Rabbi Aharon of Lunel mentions it)
- Quoted by: Maharam Alshakar, the **Radbaz** (Rabbi David ben Zimra), and others

Translation History

- **1927:** First English translation by **Samuel Rosenblatt** (from Arabic to English — same translator as Emunot VeDe'ot)
- **1965:** First Hebrew translation by **Rabbi Solomon Sassoon** (grandson of Flora Sassoon), produced in honour of the wedding of his niece Mozelle to Rabbi Abraham Gabbay (later rabbi of Ohel David, Golders Green)
- The 1965 Hebrew text is the basis of the Feldheim edition used today

Practical Notes

- The sefer is **not available on Sefaria**
- Available editions: **Feldheim** — green (Hebrew), purple (English)
- Estimated study duration: approximately **one year**

Key Themes to Watch For

1. The relationship between intellectual understanding and experiential service of God
2. Rabbi Avraham's concept of **chasidut** and what it means in his context
3. The tension/resolution between abstinence and Rambam's golden mean
4. Insights into the Rambam himself through his son's writings
5. The interplay between Jewish tradition and external practices (Sufi influence)

Primary source for this introduction: Article by David Yosef (not the Chief Rabbi), supplemented by the Feldheim introduction.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/64QvD-4k9U0 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com